14
Russia's neoliberal imperialism and the Eurasian challenge

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According to the BRICS story, first told over a decade ago by research analysts at Goldman Sachs, four emerging economies were set to become the engine of capitalism in this century. The bottom line (based on specific assumptions about development and demographics, on multiple economic projections and on a rather massive *ceteris paribus* assumption) was that Brazil, Russia, India and China had the potential of reaching an average GDP level higher than the individual growth rates of the world's six richest nations by 2040. Effectively, and provided that the 2001–03 'growth policy-settings' were maintained, the broader BRIC prediction was that the political and economic contours of the international system were undergoing a kind of great transformation (Wilson and Purushothanam 2003:2–4; in one of his projected scenarios, O'Neill 2001).

More than a decade later, forecasts originally made about BRICS would look very different and would have to be formulated in a more nuanced, even circumspect way – *The Economist*, for instance, declared that a general deceleration after 2012 marked 'the end of the first dramatic phase of the emerging-market era' (2013). Additionally, the analytical usefulness of a 'BRICS category' (the acronym now expanded to include South Africa) looks even more questionable in 2015 than in the early 2000s. And yet, the formula has stuck, and the broad questions it poses (particularly the ominous sense that the world system's balance was shifting East) have become a mainstream subject of debate (to cite but one example, see Rachman 2010). Animated by the very strong growth prospects which began visiting their economies particularly in 2006–07, BRIC countries